But Bohr was a peculiar kind of sage—brilliant and insightful, yet plodding and obscure, sometimes infuriatingly so. “It is practically impossible to describe Niels Bohr to a person who has never worked with him,” said George Gamow, a Russian physicist and former student of Bohr (who had a famously large personality himself). “Probably his most characteristic property was the slowness of his thinking and comprehension.” Gamow then described the frustration that was watching a movie with the father of quantum physics:

> The only movies Bohr liked were those called The Gun Fight at the Lazy Gee Ranch or The Lone Ranger and a Sioux Girl. But it was hard to go with Bohr to the movies. He could not follow the plot, and was constantly asking us, to the great annoyance of the rest of the audience, questions like this: “Is that the sister of that cowboy who shot the Indian who tried to steal a herd of cattle belonging to her brother-in-law?” The same slowness of reaction was apparent at scientific meetings. Many a time, a visiting young physicist (most physicists visiting Copenhagen were young) would deliver a brilliant talk about his recent calculations on some intricate problem of the quantum theory. Everybody in the audience would understand the argument quite clearly, but Bohr wouldn’t. So everybody would start to explain to Bohr the simple point he had missed, and in the resulting turmoil everybody would stop understanding anything. Finally, after a considerable period of time, Bohr would begin to understand, and it would turn out that what he understood about the problem presented by the visitor was quite different from what the visitor meant, and was correct, while the visitor’s interpretation was wrong.

For his students and colleagues, the pull of Bohr’s reputation, and his sheer force of personality, overcame the annoyances and peculiarities of working with him. If anything, those peculiarities endeared Bohr to his students more, for Bohr’s quirks allowed them to see that it was not simply that they needed Bohr—he also needed them. Bohr’s working style was slow, intense, and collaborative by nature. He was constantly wording and rewording his ideas and bouncing them off others. Writing was a painful process for Bohr, and nearly impossible for him to accomplish without help. In fact, in the years encompassing the crucial infancy of quantum theory, from 1922 to 1930, Bohr did not publish a single paper alone. And where Einstein’s writing was clear and deceptively simple, Bohr’s writing was tortuous and obscure, with famously long and convoluted sentences. Here,